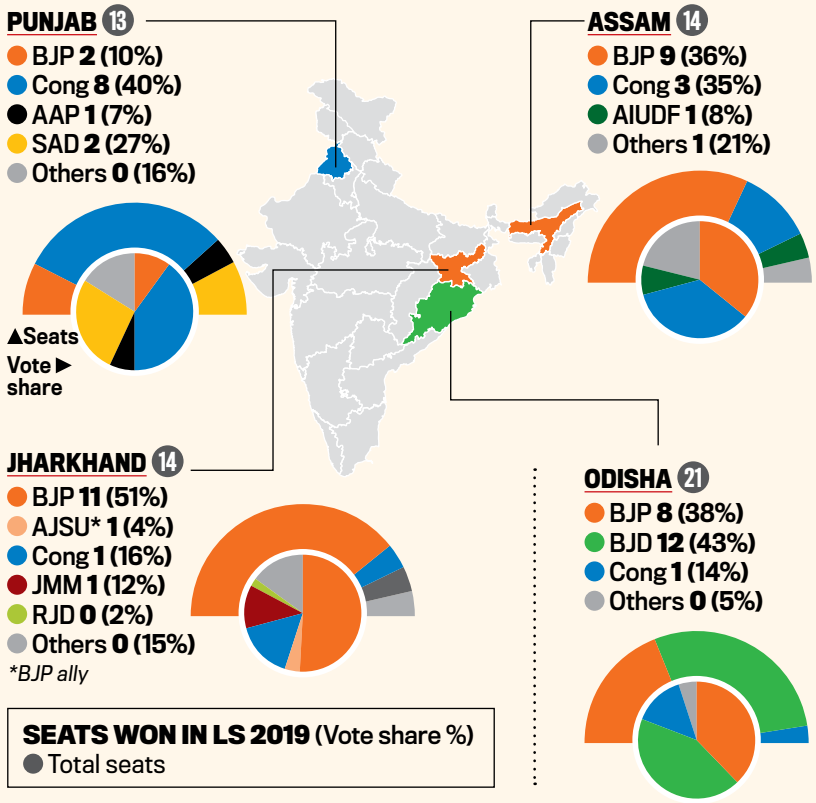
THE MAVERICKS

Except in Assam, where the balance seems to be tilted towards the BJP, non-NDA parties are likely to offer stiff fights in these states



I.N.D.I.A. on the ground. For instance, in 2019, when the SP fought in alliance with the BSP, the party with the grip over Dalit votes, and the RLD, their combined vote share could not cross 40 per cent, proving grossly insufficient to bring down the BJP. And by coming together, the SP and the Congress have already cemented the 20 per cent Muslim vote that is decisive in a dozen seats. An undesirable corollary? The coalescing of the Hindu vote around the BJP.

But the most fluid battleground by far will be Maharashtra, where untested political equations will come into play for the first time. In 2019, the BJP had combined with the undivided Shiv Sena to win 41 of the state's 48 seats. But that bonhomie came undone a few months later in the assembly election, when the Uddhav Thackeray-led Sena parted ways with the BJP and formed a government as part of the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) alliance. That government lasted 20 months before the BJP successfully engineered the MVA's break-up. First, it splintered the Sena by offering the chief minister's chair to Eknath Shinde. Then, it did the same with the other MVA constituent—the Sharad Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party (NCP)—by getting his nephew Ajit Pawar to walk out, in return for the post of deputy CM. Now, the battle lines are between the residual sections of the Sena and NCP led by Uddhav and Pawar Sr, respectively, along with the Congress, against the BJP, the Shinde Sena and the Ajit faction of the NCP. While both alliances are unnatural, psephologists say the proportion of unnaturalness will determine the final outcome. It's higher in the MVA, where the Sena-Congress-NCP combination will be tested in around 20 seats, than in the NDA where the BJP-NCP may team up in around five seats.

Most experts agree that Uddhav and Pawar Sr may get the sympathy vote, but there is no consensus on the geographic spread of the sympathy wave. "There is a significant sympathy wave for Uddhav Thackeray in and around Mumbai but no surety in other parts of the state," says Uttara Sahasrabuddhe, a former Political Science professor at the University of Mumbai. Smaller parties such as the Prakash Ambedkar-led Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi (VBA), with whom the MVA's alliance talks have progressed fitfully but fruitlessly for months, will queer the pitch further. The VBA may not have won a single seat in 2019, but its seven per cent vote share was instrumental in the defeat of a few Congress-NCP candidates, including former CMs Ashok Chavan and Sushilkumar Shinde.

Bihar, too, promises to be a tough fight, especially as the BJP took the wind out of I.N.D.I.A.'s sails by getting Nitish back on its side. Not only will this hurt the alliance's chances at the national level, but will also stymie its prospects in the state. Had Nitish stayed on, the combined vote share of the I.N.D.I.A. bloc, which includes the Tejashwi Yadav-led Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), would have been 47 per cent compared to the BJP's 24 per cent in 2019. The situation has now reversed.

To make good the shortfall, Tejashwi is now looking beyond the RJD's core M-Y support base—Muslims, who constitute 18 per cent of the population, and Yadavs, who account for 14 per cent—to woo the Extremely Backward Class (EBC) vote bank that Nitish had cultivated for the JD(U). In Nawada and Purnia, for instance, the party dismissed the claims of influential Bahubali Yadav leaders Pappu Yadav